

COURAGE AMIDST FEAR

An unprecedented coalition of forces—judges, lawyers, politicians of both secular and religious hues, civil society activists and independent media—have been providing stiff resistance to the General Musharraf's despotic rule

■ By Hasan Zaidi

The opposition to General Pervez Musharraf's declaration of martial law has brought together judges, lawyers, civil society activists, the independent media and politicians of both secular and religious hues. Now with socialites and formerly apolitical students from elite universities—the poster children for Musharraf's policy of “enlightened moderation”—also asserting their dissent, this is an unprecedented coalition of forces arrayed against the General. They come from different backgrounds and with different agendas but all have one thing in common: the desire not to allow any one individual to dictate the future of 160 million Pakistanis. INDIA TODAY details some of the most prominent faces of this resistance.

ALL FOR JUSTICE

Iftikhar Chaudhry

DEPOSED CHIEF JUSTICE, Supreme Court

The 59-year-old deposed chief justice of Pakistan has become a symbol of resistance against General Pervez Musharraf since the Pakistan President's first attempts to fire him on March 9 spectacularly backfired. Previously best known for a brusque courtroom style and for having swiftly reduced the litigation pending for years in the Supreme Court, he became a darling of the civil rights groups for his suo moto actions against official negligence and excesses. In particular, his taking up the cause of those “disappeared”—usually because of intelligence agencies—made him a cause celebre with ordinary Pakistanis. General Musharraf accuses him of corruption and of transgressing into the domain of the executive, but it is widely believed that it was his efforts to assert the judiciary's independence that led to his sacking. Awarded Medal of Freedom by the Harvard Law School, he has been called “the real Chief Justice” by Benazir Bhutto. He remains defiant under house arrest: “God blessed me with success last time and I am sure that He would bless me again.”

HE HAS BECOME THE SYMBOL OF RESISTANCE AND A DARLING OF THE CIVIL RIGHTS GROUPS. HOUSE ARREST HASN'T QUIETENED HIS FORCEFUL VOICE.

